



M1A2 Abrams

The American Abrams has been made in large numbers (some 11,000) and now equips seven national armies. Nevertheless, it has been subject to the West’s ambivalent attitude to tanks—the dilemma of potentially needing them and seeing others still developing them versus the pressure on factory capacity amid tightening military budgets.

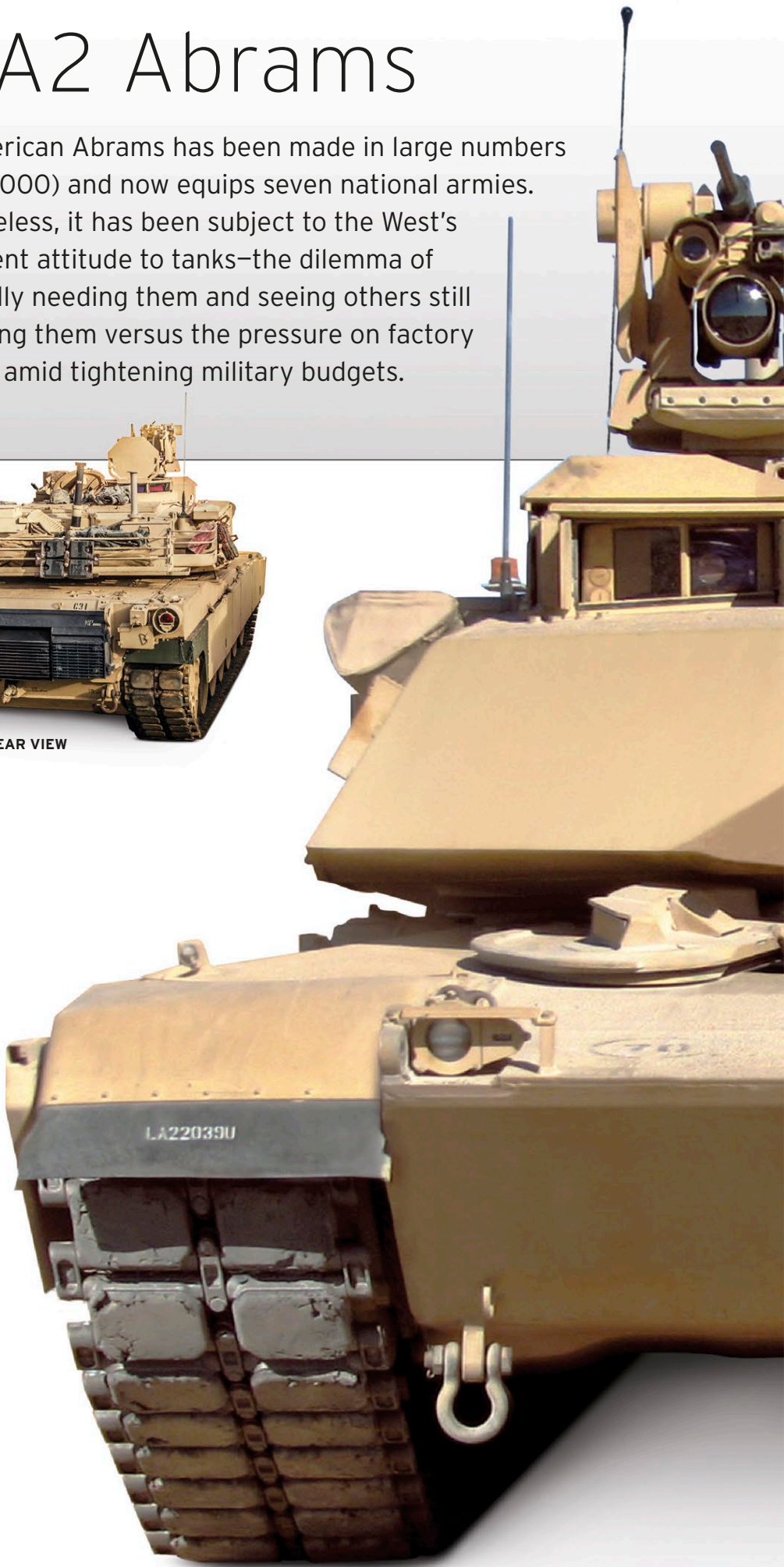
THE ABRAMS WAS DESIGNED as a replacement for the M60 at a time when Soviet Bloc tanks were considered the most likely enemy. The first model was equipped with a version of the L7 105mm gun from the UK, separate ammunition storage in a blow-out compartment to protect the crew, and a gas turbine engine that was small and incredibly powerful but twice as thirsty as an equivalent diesel engine. During a visit to the UK in 1973, an American team was shown the latest developments in Chobham armor, and this led to a redesign of the tank to incorporate the new protection system. Later, a new version of the laminate armor incorporating depleted uranium was fitted to the M1A1 model of the tank, doubling protection levels. The M1A1 was also equipped with the 120mm German smoothbore gun, which gave it a tremendous advantage in the 1991 Gulf War.

Further upgrades, such as a new Fire Control System, Commander’s Independent Thermal Viewer, and improved digital systems, led to the M1A2 model. City fighting in the Iraq War led to the development of the Tank Urban Survival Kit (TUSK) in 2006. These were fitted to tanks in theater to improve protection in built-up areas.

Time and again the Abrams has proved itself in battle, and it will undoubtedly continue to be a potent weapon for decades to come.



REAR VIEW



SPECIFICATIONS	
Name	M1A2 Abrams
Date	1992
Origin	USA
Production	Approx 1,500
Engine	Textron Lycoming AGT1500 gas turbine, 1,500hp
Weight	69.4 tons (63 tonnes)
Main armament	120mm M256 smoothbore
Secondary armament	.50 Browning M2HB, 2 x 7.62mm M240 MGs
Crew	4
Armor thickness	Unknown

A schematic diagram of the M1A2 Abrams tank's interior layout, showing the positions of the crew members. The diagram is a top-down view of the turret and hull. Labels with lines pointing to specific areas indicate the locations of the Engine, Commander, Gunner, Loader, and Driver.